Stepanek Poetry Collection

By Matthew Joseph Thaddeus Stephanek

I am Mattie J.T. Stepanek.

My body has light skin,

Red blood, blue eyes, and blond hair.

Since I have mitochondrial myopathy,

I even have a trach, a ventilator, and oxygen.

Very poetic, I am, and very smart, too.

I am always brainstorming ideas and stories.

I am a survivor, but some day, I will see

My two brothers and one sister in Heaven.

When I grow up, I plan to become

A daddy, a writer, a public speaker,

And most of all, a peacemaker.

Whoever I am, and whatever happens,

I will always love my body and mind,

Even if it has different abilities

Than other people's bodies and minds.

I will always be happy, because

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I will always be me.

INTRODUCTION

In the words of former US President Jimmy Carter, "Matthew Joseph Thaddeus Stepanek reminds us how easy it is to forgive others, to find something amazing even in the most trivial things and to celebrate the little gifts of life each day." Mattie, as he is best known throughout the world, began writing poetry at age three and since birth has suffered from a rare form of muscular dystrophy. In the poems "The ME Poem", "Circle of Happiness", "Heartsong", "About Living" "MDA Summer Camp Is", and "About Heaven", Mattie confronts his mortality through the power of words that inspire and enrich the human spirit.

Mattie died June 22, 2004.

The "ME" Poem

Magic of Heartsongs,

Afraid of a memory and the dark,

Truthful and sincere,

Teacher of peace,

Inspiring, intelligent, lover of ice crea,

Enthusiastic and ebullient

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Sunset watcher, shell and rock collector,
Tiger in Martial Arts,
Excited about celebrating life,
Playful, prayerful, patient,
Always ready with a hug and smile,
Never at a loss for words,
Energetic (like the Energizer Bunny)
Keeps on reading and writing
And reading and writing…
This is me!

Circle of Happiness

I am a little kid
For you to love.
I am a little kid
For you to hug and kiss.
I am a little kid
For you to say,
"You are so special,
Yes you are" to.

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I am a little kid
For all of those things
And more.
And when you
Feel and say and do
All of those things,
I will be a little kid
Who will love you.
I will be a little kid
Who will hug and kiss you.
I will be a little kid
Who will say to you,
"You are so special, too,
Yes you are."
I will be a little kid
Who will do all of those things
And more.
And that is what
Happiness
Is all about.

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Heartsong

I have a song, deep in my heart,
And only I can hear it.
If I close my eyes and sit very still
It is so easy to listen to my song.
When my eyes are open and
I am so busy and moving and busy,
If I take time and listen very hard,
I can still hear my Heartsong.
It makes me feel happy.
Happier than ever.
Happier than everywhere.
And everything and everyone
In the whole wide world.
Happy like thinking about
Going to Heaven when I die.
My Heartsong sounds like this - -

I love you! I love you!
How happy you can be!
How happy you can make
This whole world be!

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And sometimes it's other
Tunes and words, too,
But it always sings the
Same special feeling to me.
It makes me think of
Jamie, and Katie and Stevie,
And other wonderful things.
This is my special song
But do you know what?
All people have a special song
Inside their hearts!
Everyone in the whole wide world
Has a special Heartsong.
If you believe in magical, musical hearts,
And if you believe you can be happy,
Then you, too, will hear your song.

About Living

Although I am
Greatly anticipating
Going to Heaven

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When I die,
I would really like
To finish my life
On earth as a mortal
For a long time first.
But,
I know that life
On earth is limited.
And,
I know that Life
In Heaven is eternal.
So,
Every day,
No matter who we are,
What we do, or
Where we are,
We must celebrate
The gift of life on earth
While we have it,
For ever.

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MDA Summer Camp Is

MDA Summer Camp is
…A place where kids wish
Onto paper that is placed into
Balloon-carried baskets,
Then hopefully pray as
Their thoughts and dreams
Ascend into the heavens.
MDA Summer Camp is
…A feeling of friends
Helping friends,
Whoever they are,
However they are,
Wherever they are,
For whatever reason,
Just because they are.
MDA Summer Camp is
…An understanding
That the worth of a person
Should never be measured
By number of years lived, or

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By physical or mental abilities,

But by the strength of spirit.

MDA Summer Camp is

….A time for commemoration,

And liberation,

And rejuvenation,

And celebration,

In spite of the realities of life.

…Thank God, that

MDA Summer Camp IS.

About Heaven

Now, I will tell you about Heaven.

Where is Heaven?

It is way over there, and

It is way over there, and

It is way over there, too.

It is everywhere.

What does it look like?

It looks like school, and

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It looks like a farm, and

It looks like a home.

It looks like Everything.

What does it sound like?

Well,

I really don't know,

Because I am just

A little big boy

With a brother,

And another brother and sister,

And a friend,

Who live in the

Everywhere and Everything of Heaven.

But perhaps,

Heaven sounds like

Forever.

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SOURCE INFORMATION

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